

1. University Of Pennsylvania

1. Email address

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2. Which school will you be attending?

University of Alliance

3. What does your school look for in an application?

UPENN's mission statement is "to strengthen the quality of education, and to produce innovative research and models of healthcare delivery by fostering a vibrant inclusive environment and fully embracing diversity." The growth process of this institution is founded on the early idea of creating a facility that trains the art of caring and transforming communities.

The statement has these key components:

1. Promoting innovations and research
2. Improving communities

We look for students who aspire to develop and refine their talents and abilities within Penn's liberal arts-based, practical, and interdisciplinary learning

environment. Our ideal candidates are inspired to emulate our founder Benjamin Franklin by applying their knowledge in “service to society” to our community, the city of Philadelphia, and the wider world. To best understand prospective students’ paths through Penn, we approach applications with a well-rounded whole-person review and with great care.

Penn has a proud tradition of translating knowledge into social-minded action that dates back to our founder Benjamin Franklin. This tradition of active pragmatism, articulated in Franklin’s maxim “well-done is better than well-said,” lives today through inclusive policies, innovative work, and the impactful engagement of our faculty, students, and staff.

Diversity- Nearly half of Penn’s undergraduates self-identify as students of color, more than half are women, 13 percent are among the first in their families to attend college, and 13 percent are international. The spectrum of valuable perspectives and ensuing dialogue are key contributors to educational excellence and an inclusive, dynamic campus environment.

Penn believes that a student who values diversity can’t resist an opportunity to try something new. They love learning new and different skills and meeting people from other backgrounds. Branching Out is the only way to develop a diverse background and achieve a wider perspective that enables you to serve others effectively.

Benjamin Franklin, our founder, was an American polymath who was active as a writer, scientist, inventor, statesman, diplomat, printer, publisher, and political philosopher. Among the leading intellectuals of his time, Franklin was one of the Founding Fathers of the United States, a drafter and signer of the United States Declaration of Independence, and the first United States Postmaster General. Penn encourages growing outside of your comfort space and exploring other passions and interests. Franklin’s relentless curiosity and willingness to persist through setbacks fueled his creation of many inventions. Many other big inventions have been made at Penn, including the first general-purpose electronic computer, ENIAC, which was constructed and operated here at The Moore School of Electrical Engineering in 1946, now part of the School of Engineering and Applied Science.

Innovation, Integrated Knowledge

Solving today's complex problems requires knowledge that crosses traditional boundaries. True to our roots, Penn encourages both intellectual and practical pursuits and has attracted some of the most eminent interdisciplinary scholars and teachers working today through our Penn Integrates Knowledge program.

Research Discovery

Penn is one of the world's most powerful research and teaching institutions, with a research budget of nearly \$1.1 billion and more than 5,000 active faculty members. The scale and interdisciplinary character of research and teaching set Penn apart, and our highly ranked Perelman School of Medicine is one of the top recipients of NIH funding in the country.

Penn's academics are boosted by its inherent culture and ecosystem of innovation. You name it, if it's cutting-edge, the University's faculty—and students—have their hands in it. Grounded in the liberal arts and sciences and enriched by the integrated resources of four undergraduate and 12 graduate schools, Penn offers students an unparalleled education informed by inclusivity, intellectual rigor, research, and the impetus to create new knowledge to the benefit of individuals and communities around the world.

Impact

Effecting potent positive impact in our neighborhoods, nation, and world are the bricks on which democracy and global citizenship are built, and are the cornerstones of a Penn education.

Community engagement, Service & Dedication:

When Benjamin Franklin founded the University of Pennsylvania in 1740, he had a vision for the new college and was determined to set it apart from other colleges by its mark of service. As a result, the admission officers at Penn will be carefully looking at your test scores, grades, and essays, but they will also be interested to see how you give back to your community. Underneath the GPA and scores on your application is someone who has goals for their future. You have a chance to show them what you care about and how you give back

to your community. While reading your application, Penn's admission officers will be looking for traits that mirror service and loyalty.

Penn wants to know how you used your talents to serve your community. They want to see a student who saw a problem and used their strengths to fix it or propose a new idea that brought positive change.

Action and Leadership: The University of Pennsylvania's ideal student loves taking initiative and seeks to improve the state of their surroundings. Natural leaders often feel the pull to do what no one else is willing to do, and this is true of many Penn students.

Details, Honesty, and Self-awareness: University of Pennsylvania admissions is known for approaching applications holistically, meaning that they believe every part of the application is interconnected, and each piece directly affects every other part.

As a result, they want to know how you operate in relationships, leadership positions, and uncomfortable situations. In your application, be honest; they want to see the whole picture. Overall, it's important to know that Penn takes a uniquely holistic approach. Everything you include in your application will be considered interconnected and relevant. They won't let any details slip through their grasp without considering how it reveals your unique personality.

The ideal Penn student takes initiative and uses their strengths to make the community around them better. They're always focused on how situations can improve and how they can practically use their talents. The student who will thrive at Penn has a vision for themselves and their community and is ready to put that vision into action through their education.

4. What are some of the loopholes in the admissions process that we can use to the scholars' advantage?

Penn has 4 Undergraduate Schools, each with hidden requirements.
At the College: We would like to see:

- o a curiosity in the humanities, social sciences, and natural sciences
- o an ability to apply classroom knowledge to the real world
- o a strong preparation in a balanced and advanced college preparatory curriculum

At Penn Engineering: We would like to see:

- o an ability to innovate, design, and practically apply scientific discoveries
- o expressed reasons for pursuing an engineering education
- o a strong preparation in physics and mathematics, particularly calculus

At Penn Nursing, We would like to see:

- o a commitment to patient care
- o a desire to explore issues in health care
- o a strong preparation in the sciences, particularly in chemistry

At Wharton, We would like to see:

- o interest in the business to fuel positive change to advance the world's economic and social well-being
- o demonstrated leadership
- o a strong preparation in mathematics, particularly calculus

Pre-professionalism: Penn is very preprofessional. Demonstrate interest to join the workforce while on campus, or you are already actively involved. Penn has a history of launching their graduates into their careers with gusto, students start internships from their freshman year. The connections that being a student at Penn bring you are endless. Even if you're unsure of what you'd like to pursue after college, having a Penn degree will set you up for success, so have a plan. Penn has an entire Career Services department that features job listings, career fairs, and career counseling.

Worldly approach: Penn is big on Study Abroad, and Internships abroad, and as such, it extremely values students with knowledge in a Foreign language or demonstrated interest in one.

Connected Across Disciplines: Penn is famous for its Interdisciplinary studies & approach to innovation. If you're planning to apply to the university, you might already know that Penn is known for competitive dual degree programs.

Applying to these competitive programs already sends a message that your mindset is Penn material. Also, if you are not accepted into the program, you

stand a chance of acceptance into one of the schools from which the program is formed.

DMD: Digital Media Design Program

Huntsman: The Huntsman Program in International Studies and Business

LSM: The Roy and Diana Vagelos Program in Life Sciences and Management

M&T: The Jerome Fisher Program in Management and Technology

NETS: The Rajendra and Neera Singh Program in Networked and Social Systems Engineering

NHCM: Nursing and Healthcare Management

Seven-Year Bio-Dental Program

VIPER: The Roy and Diana Vagelos Integrated Program in Energy Research

Innovation & Research: Students showing potential/progress in these areas are more likely to get accepted.

Connected Across Schools: Policies and programs often reach even beyond to incorporate multiple schools or even universities.

Connected Across Communities: Penn students overwhelmingly appreciate and contribute to West Philadelphia and the many communities within it. Penn is big on community engagement and service.

Connected Across Cultures: There are many other residential programs to fit students' global interests like Cultures Collective and Living Cultures Program Community. This ties back to diversity.

Applications reflecting deep knowledge & understanding, interest, and fit for the above 'connections' are more likely to be accepted.

Social culture: work hard, play hard (Strong work-life balance)

Diversity quotas:

- International students: 13%
- First-generation college students: 16%

- In Fall 2020, the largest racial demographic of Penn undergrads were white students (36%), followed by Asian-American/Pacific Islander (25%), Hispanic/Latinx (11%), and African American/Black (8%).

Community Engagement: This is a huge plus for any application to Penn, one might even add that it's a necessity for admission.

2. Cornell University

College Of Arts And Sciences

1. Email address

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2. Which school will you be attending?

Cornell University, College of Arts and Sciences

3. What does your school look for in an application?

One must show a deep love and commitment to Cornell, that if admitted, one will surely attend. For A&S specifically, one must show interdisciplinary and multifaceted learning, because of two things, one, it's a liberal arts college, and two, it's one of the ideals ingrained in the motto, 'Any Person... Any Study'. The other idea is diversity. One should also show community engagement due to Cornell being a Land Grant university, so they have to give back to the state of New York.

4. What are some of the loopholes in the admissions process that we can use to the scholars' advantage?

A focus on the yield rate makes Cornell admit students who show a deep commitment to the university. A decentralized college system allows for one to apply to a college with a lower acceptance rate. Some courses are offered by two colleges in collaboration with each other, eg. Environment and Sustainability, offered by CALS and CAS in conjunction with each other.

3. Dartmouth College

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2. Which school will you be attending?

Dartmouth College

3. What does your school look for in an application?

FGLI, explorative individuals ready to try out new things and experience a multitude of cultures and people, creative writing styles, and individuals who value community and partnership

The majority of the Kenyans who got in this year had a music/art/ sport forte as well as their major. If this is something you see in your application, you might want to consider Dartmouth.

Why Dartmouth blog:

<https://admissions.dartmouth.edu/follow/blog/gavin-fry/its-why-dartmouth-time-p-art-2-home>

Alumni interview blog:

<https://admissions.dartmouth.edu/follow/blog/caroline-york/alumni-interview>

4. What are some of the loopholes in the admissions process that we can use to the scholars' advantage?

Applicant needs to be very unconventional. Because it's a liberal arts school, don't bank too much on spikes(although it's important) but you need to holistic, explorative, and a very good writer.

Also, Playing the African card wisely

Freshman year experience:

<https://admissions.dartmouth.edu/follow/blog/brandon-mioduszewski/freshman-year-retrospective>

An interesting tradition:

<https://admissions.dartmouth.edu/follow/blog/jack-heaphy/taking-my-professor-lunch>

4. Minerva University

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2. Which school will you be attending?

Minerva University

3. What does your school look for in an application?

Minerva is heavily set on activities and accomplishments. It requires each applicant to not only give a 500-word description of each activity but also provide 6 pieces of evidence supporting each one. Minerva is a very selective school and based on its 2% acceptance rate, I will advise you to apply only as a last resort. It is a fairly new institution and is trying to create a brand. This means that you don't have the "African" card that is so vital in ESP. However, if you insist on applying (against my sincere warning), I will share my advice and what got me in.

You need to be colorful. Imagine your activities as a pallet. You should use all your colors. Unlike in the common app, you only have 5 slots. Be as diverse as possible, you never know what stands out to the AOs. I have variety in my

activities, all stellar in my opinion. From art club to ICT to community service. My "spike" was computer science but I showed my humanitarian side in all the activities. You should do this too.

Minerva is a very tech-centered school, if you're not applying for CS or business(with tech), consider other schools(even Juja Boys).

Minerva wants to build a student from scratch, a "global citizen". That is why we travel the world through our semesters. In your application, you must show that you are open-minded and ready to accept new information. This will be vital in each country you visit and as a Minerva student.

You will also be tested separately, think of it like an SAT for people who don't like the SAT. That is all I am legally allowed to say about the test. Good luck.

4. What are some of the loopholes in the admissions process that we can use to the scholars' advantage?

I like Minerva because it asks for proof of the activities you provide. That is something I see common app adopting soon, it is a sure way of filtering lies. But it is also its greatest weakness. The proof is relative, and it can also be faked. When giving proof, make sure to include certificates of the event or award (it took me 10 minutes to make one online). Include contacts of teachers or friends you "worked" with who will give stellar feedback to the admission officers. They WILL reach out and ask about the activities. In my case, they wanted to see bank cheques for the 300k we "raised" for an event. Give as much evidence as possible, and let them be relevant.

The first review of your app is by students. If you're writing about an app you developed, including specifics about what language and framework you used.

Again, Minerva is trying to create a brand for itself, it needs people who "know their stuff".

Minerva also includes an option for attaching images and pdfs. Here submit recommendations from teachers about that specific event and use that chance to write about other activities. You can't be summarised in 5 activities, so pour out more of yourself into these attachments.

Create websites and make google sheets to give an account of what you did and how you did it. Again, the AOs need to know that you are a real person and your activities are also real.

Lastly, the biggest loophole to Minerva is the decision to apply. Minerva is amazing and you will have the time of your life. I am not gatekeeping a great institution, I am only warning you as I had been warned. Make a very informed decision (both financially and career-wise), and you will undoubtedly get in.

5. Duke University

1. Email address

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2. Which school will you be attending?

Duke

3. What does your school look for in an application?

✓ Students interested in high-level research- I mentioned in detail a new solar panel technology for Perovskites and its potential to convert UV and Infrared.

✓ Athletes- Team Captains, Basketball, Soccer, Swimming, at least one sport and be very good at it.

✓ Researchers and Experimentalists- scholars should have a meaningful project in his / her community. The more verifiable the better. But recommendation letters and a CV are required for the Karsh Scholarship. I mentioned a solar project that generated 4kWh of power, storing it in a gel battery, (specific projects and explanations on how they work will boost someone's chances)

✓ FGLI/ Single parent or orphaned/-other challenges - they sympathize with the African Card, but it should not be a sob story all through, you have to show that you have overcome such trials and you are mentally fit.

4. What are some of the loopholes in the admissions process that we can use to the scholars' advantage?

✓ They value athletes, like serious high achieving athletes. Duke is a championship school.

7. Northwestern University

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2. Which school will you be attending?

Northwestern University

3. What does your school look for in an application?

Good writers with an African touch. Playing the diversity card will go a long way in the application. Northwestern also looks for a scholar's specificity in his area of study.

I believe Northwestern values the "AND" mentality in its students. I, for instance, showed how I work to achieve my goals through different avenues, whether it be through music, drama, or writing. I brought all these different

colors of my life to paint one narrative - I am a student passionate about global health.

4. What are some of the loopholes in the admissions process that we can use to the scholars' advantage?

Applying through the college of arts and sciences to allow for less competition. This depends on whether the school allows for changing colleges.

I do have one about a school that I have many reasons to believe accepted me, but rescinded my acceptance after they noticed inconsistencies in my application from my LinkedIn profile, but not Northwestern particularly.

From the successful applications that I have read, coupled with my own missed application, I believe Harvard looks for African students who have gone through a lot of challenges but have sailed through to make significant contributions to their communities. The same goes for Stanford which looks for thoughtful essays. These two schools more or less look for the same profile in an African applicant.

In their supplements, both schools have the same prompt: A letter to your future roommate. An applicant who falls in the regular pool should only answer the prompt in the case of Stanford, but not Harvard. (You know these schools low-key compete for the same set of highly talented applicants, so showing Harvard that you applied to Stanford and that you stand a higher chance of being accepted there, might cause them to reject you.)

7. St. Lawrence university

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2. Which school will you be attending?

St. Lawrence university

3. What does your school look for in an application?

SLU looks for students who show a genuine commitment to attend if accepted. Not having any supplemental essay is a "trick" as they expect you to at least mention two reasons why you think you're a fit and how SLU will help you achieve your goal.

4. What are some of the loopholes in the admissions process that we can use to the scholars' advantage?

SLU has a very tight-knit community and looks for students who value that. Particularly, they look for students who have faced discrimination/violence in their families and communities at large as they believe that SLU will be a welcoming environment for them. For this reason, the personal statement should show one's extreme vulnerability and suffering within a community that was supposed to support the person. (Applicants to apply for the Kenyan scholars' program)

8. Swarthmore College

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2. Which school will you be attending?

Swarthmore College

3. What does your school look for in an application?

Intellectual curiosity. Swat takes pride in how hard their classes are, and they want to see that you are capable of keeping up. Present yourself as someone who loves to ask how, when, and why

Personality. They have a preference for applicants who demonstrate deep compassion for others. "Minding the Light" which refers to the practice of learning to see the divine light in others and ourselves is a Quaker value Swat upholds. You must also be team-oriented.

Intellectual curiosity and an enthusiasm for learning: We are looking for students who genuinely enjoy learning and are uncommonly curious. Students relish the opportunities presented by our selection of 40+ academic programs, an extraordinarily devoted faculty, and a one-of-a-kind honors program.

Creative and proactive problem-solving. Open-mindedness in general and to the liberal arts writ large. Civic Engagement. Willingness to work hard. Show academic initiative.

Swarthmore is a highly academic institution. The majority of undergrads join grad school within 5 yrs of graduation. Having a spike in a specific field of interest coupled with interests in other fields is very important (Appreciation for the liberal arts nature of the school).

4. What are some of the loopholes in the admissions process that we can use to the scholars' advantage?

Everyone in Swarthmore is an activist in their way. Show them that you care about what is going on in your community and that you are going out of your way to fight for social justice.

Although they don't track demonstrated interest, creating a rapport with your regional AO (Andrew Moe for Africa) 'may' tilt things in your favor.

Ensure you have great recommendation letters which reflect you are a very curious student.

Applying ED to Swarthmore increases your chances by a lot. Isinta broke the streak, where Swarthmore hadn't admitted anyone from the RD pool for quite a while.

Demonstrate deep interest in an academic field, and tie it to a problem(s) you'd like to solve. (Mind the 250-word limit) Effective use of words is key.

9. Princeton University

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2. Which school will you be attending?

Princeton University

3. What does your school look for in an application?

Being an Ivy, a spike is a must. 'Nerdiness' is highly appreciated at Princeton so applications that display deep passion and knowledge ie. meaningful jargon, and research in a particular field stand out. From the academics at Princeton, it's pretty clear that they prefer applicants whose focus is in a particular field as the school doesn't offer minors but has concentrations instead. Quite a several alumni have Nobel prizes in their field of study and from the website, you can

see that Princeton appreciates students who are very academic and are planning to delve into the world of academia in their field.

Princeton is also very pro scores hence high SAT scores and transcripts are a plus. As with all top-tier schools, excellent academic performance is expected. Also, a student who took a foreign language till form four has a higher chance of being accepted; on the academic preparation website, it's expected for most students to have undertaken four years of a foreign language in high school if possible. I think the reason for this is every student pursuing a Bachelor of Arts is required to take a foreign language and where possible undergo an immersive language experience ie. visiting the native country of the language.

<https://admission.princeton.edu/how-apply/academic-preparation>

Proficiency in writing is also sought after as all international students are expected to submit a graded written paper in their application. This could be due to the compulsory freshman writing seminar hence the need for students with some level of prowess in academic writing. When I was applying, the advice I received from the majority of Princeton students was to select an English Literature essay where I had scored from 17 and up out of 20 and one in which the teacher had left good remarks with just a touch of criticism.

An applicant who has undertaken meaningful community service to an underrepresented or underprivileged group of people for a significant amount of time will be at an advantage. The informal motto of Princeton in the nation's service and the service of humanity, Civic engagement is highly encouraged at Princeton and there's even the Princeton Internships in Civic Service program which you can read more about <https://pics.princeton.edu>

To further demonstrate this emphasis on civic service, there's an essay where you're required to describe how the applicant has served their community and how they plan to in the future. An applicant who intends to take part in specific research that benefits the community may also have an upper hand.

Intellectual curiosity is also sought after by admissions officers. The school's focus on meaningful research is seen through the junior paper/senior thesis requirement in a particular field of study. An applicant who displays a clear passion for research and a thirst for knowledge ie. by going out of their way to learn something is more likely to get accepted. This passion can be displayed through their activities and the 'Why Major' essay.

4. What are some of the loopholes in the admissions process that we can use to the scholars' advantage?

Playing whatever diversity card the scholar has is very advantageous whether it's low income, first-generation (Princeton is need-blind to all applicants), LGBTQ+, or women in STEM. One common factor among most Princeton students especially Kenyans who were accepted is that their application utilized one of these cards and showed some level of discrimination faced due to these identities. Another common factor among most Princeton applicants who are accepted is they all show some form of non-conformity whether it's challenging traditional norms, having a different opinion from one's society, or doing something out of the norm(legal of course). The emphasis placed on this is clear through the required essay: 'Describe a time you had a conflicting opinion with somebody, how you went about discussing it while maintaining a respectful dialogue.'

Additionally, the University's policy on Free Speech further justifies this claim: Because the University is committed to free and open inquiry in all matters, it

guarantees all members of the University community the broadest possible latitude to speak, write, listen, challenge, and learn. Except insofar as limitations on that freedom are necessary to the functioning of the University, Princeton University fully respects and supports the freedom of all members of the University community "to discuss any problem that presents itself."

Of course, the ideas of different members of the University community will often and quite naturally conflict. But it is not the proper role of the University to attempt to shield individuals from ideas and opinions they find unwelcome, disagreeable, or even deeply offensive. Although the University greatly values civility, and although all members of the University community share in the responsibility for maintaining a climate of mutual respect, concerns about civility and mutual respect can never be used as a justification for closing off discussion of ideas, however offensive or disagreeable those ideas may be to some members "

Applying to majors that are not very popular at the school is also a good strategy as applying to highly populated and competitive majors such as Computer Science reduces the chances of being admitted.

Since Princeton values writing, excellent, unconventional essays are a must.

Princeton does not track demonstrated interest at all but they value their alumni so reaching out to alumni and showing a willingness to be a loyal alumni is a plus.

10. Bryn Mawr College

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2. Which school will you be attending?

Bryn Mawr college

3. What does your school look for in an application?

Bryn Mawr College as the gender requirement suggests looks for strong women. Feminists to be precise. They want someone who values sisterhood and bonding with the small community. They also value community engagement.

4. What are some of the loopholes in the admissions process that we can use to the scholars' advantage?

Bryn Mawr selects a large pool of its students during early decision

11. Cornell University

College Of Agriculture and Life Sciences

1. Email address

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2. Which school will you be attending?

Cornell University (College Of Agriculture and Life Sciences)

3. What does your school look for in an application?

GRADES-Cornell is a demanding academic institution. We've seen incidents where students have committed suicide as a result of the rigorous academic program. To ameliorate such cases, Cornell looks for students who have excelled academically, ensuring their transition to the Cornell rigorous curriculum easier. It is therefore no surprise that the Cornell admissions officers look at your grades as the first step in evaluating your application. If your grades do not meet the cut, your application will not be evaluated.

"Your grades MUST be outstanding. In the first review, the admissions staff of each college acts as gatekeepers by looking at the applicants' academic performances to determine whether the student will do well at Cornell. This assessment relies on all scores and grades submitted by the students but will place the heaviest weight on their high school records. Those who make it to the next step are not the ones that have E's and F's on their transcript. "Even if you are an outstanding student who's a great fit for Cornell and have wonderful extracurricular activities ... there's not much I can say about you." J Locke (CALS admissions officer)

EXPERIENCE- If you're thinking of going to Cornell, you'll need to be well-versed in your field. You'll have a hard time deciding what to major in because there are eight undergraduate institutions that operate autonomously and offer over 4000 majors. Don't make the mistake of applying to a major simply because you're 'passionate' about it. Being passionate is okay, but what have you done to build on this passion? How many projects have you done? What is your work experience? What drew you to the program at Cornell rather than one at another university? How did you hear about Cornell's program? Is there a particular professor with whom you'd want to collaborate? I believe by now you get what I mean. Take your time to know your major and let your activities and honors scream your interest.

HOW INFORMED ARE YOU ABOUT YOUR HOME COLLEGE?-Unlike most Universities, Cornell's admission process is done at the college level. This basically means each college has its own admissions committee. You ideally want to prove to your home college that their college will be the best fit for you. I find telling them about general Cornell traditions too cliché and counterintuitive. Let the general Cornell traditions take a secondary seat in your essay and focus more on writing an essay that is specifically addressed to your desired college.

YOUR QUALITIES- Admission officers also look for other qualities that would contribute to the Cornell community, such as persistence and community ties. While Cornell doesn't expect "a long list of activities," admissions staff hope to discover these values from the essay and extracurricular activities. It could be 'you know what, I go to a school where I have to commute by bus or walk to school daily for two hours every day,' or things like overcoming health issues, different family situations, or being in a small community. A passion for contributing to and becoming part of the community is also extremely important, according.

4. What are some of the loopholes in the admissions process that we can use to the scholars' advantage?

Once a student passes the first review, their material is taken to the next step, in which Cornell's admissions staff will start looking at whether the student will be a good fit for Cornell and their intended programs — not just whether they are prepared for the rigorous curriculum, but also if they have certain traits and qualities that will allow them to make the most of Cornell.

Admissions officers are looking for students who can make the most out of the "any person ... any study" environment, and who can learn from and collaborate with students from all kinds of backgrounds and majors. Sometimes, this quality — or the "missing piece" in the students' and parents' understanding of admissions — even outweighs academic performance in the evaluation process.

Tan an admissions officer at CALS also said that coming from a farm is "absolutely" an advantage in CALS admissions. She explained that the number of students that admission officers see coming from production and agriculture backgrounds is "dwindling," so they will "take a close look" at those applicants.

You should also show some commitment to Cornell, which means applying for Early Decision.